

Gies AI For Impact Build-A-Thon Impact Report

Executive Summary

The Gies Build-A-Thon generated strong participation and sustained engagement across the event, from initial registration through full team completion. More than 120 participants signed up, 30 teams took part, and 22 teams completed the event from start to finish, indicating meaningful retention and commitment.

Event details - <https://build-a-thon.dsrs.illinois.edu/>

Final Results - <https://ikompete.dsrs.illinois.edu/competition/14>

Participation Outcomes

Participation levels were strong across the core event metrics.

- Total signups exceeded 120 participants.
- A total of 30 teams participated in the Build-A-Thon.
- Of those, 22 teams remained engaged through the full event timeline and completed the experience end to end.

These figures suggest that the event was successful not only in attracting interest, but also in maintaining active team involvement through completion.

Community Engagement and Support

Community support infrastructure played an important role in sustaining participant activity throughout the event. Preparatory workshops were done by Discord-based assistance, and direct email outreach helped create a high-touch support environment for participants.

- Preparatory workshops received 200 total signups.
- More than 50 support tickets were created on Discord for mentor and technical assistance.
- Participants posted more than 100 messages in Discord directed to HackClaw.

- HackClaw sent more than 500 emails over the course of the event.

Platform Adoption and Impact

A notable outcome of the challenge was the adoption of Microsoft Copilot Studio among participants. Copilot Studio recorded the largest single-day usage at UIUC during the event, demonstrating unusually strong engagement with the platform.

Many students also entered the challenge with limited or no prior awareness of Copilot Studio. As a result, the event served not only as a competition, but also as an introduction to an emerging tool that many participants had not previously explore

LIKLEDIN STUDENT QUOTES

“24 hours. One shot. We walked in with an idea and walked out with a system that turns job postings into consulting opportunities.” - Prateek Verma

<https://www.linkedin.com/feed/update/urn:li:activity:7453787041286361088/>

“Every time one of us hit a wall, someone else picked it up — that’s how HireFlow got built.” - Purab Arora

<https://www.linkedin.com/feed/update/urn:li:activity:7454589500653088768/>

“Multi-agent systems aren’t the future — they’re already reshaping how decisions get made” -Juan Zapata

<https://www.linkedin.com/feed/update/urn:li:activity:7454367874472673281/>

“Under 24 hours, we built something that thinks like a CFO and moves faster than one.”
- Xinying Fu

<https://www.linkedin.com/feed/update/urn:li:activity:7454707907176206336/>

“24 hours, no code — we built a campaign manager that actually manages campaigns”
- Harvin Patel

<https://www.linkedin.com/feed/update/urn:li:activity:7454630967438336000/>

ORGANIC MEDIA - Before Event

Vishal -

https://www.linkedin.com/posts/vishalsachdev_msbaatgies-ugcPost-7453222023301922817-GqP4

Operational Impact

The combination of workshop participation, active Discord usage, and high-volume email communication reflects a well-supported event ecosystem. These engagement channels likely contributed to participant retention, smoother team progress, and stronger overall completion outcomes. Five project champions, supported by numerous mentors from Gies and the school, were instrumental in the event's grand success.

Conclusion

The Gies AI for Impact Build-a-thon showed solid performance across both participation and support metrics. High signup volume, strong team completion, and active communication across workshops, Discord, and email indicate an event structure that was both engaging and operationally effective.